situation. The flooding was an issue that Ratan had warned them about, but they had not given it much thought.

Ratan sat through the forty-five-minute presentation without uttering a word. Afterwards, Wagh went up to him and said, ‘You had told us.’ Ratan put him at ease. Wagh says that he ‘has not seen in anyone else’ this ‘high level of empathy’.

Another significant aspect of Ratan’s personality is his stubborn resistance to accept credit for his own achievements. And if one praises him, as Venu Srinivasan says, he almost becomes a ‘shrinking violet’ and in a typical American way, responds, ‘Oh shucks.’ At every instance, he deflects credit from himself and is quick to pass it on to his team, something that was starkly evident during the interviews he gave for this book. Speaking some five years before he stepped down as chairman, Tata Sons, in an interview he gave internally, he refused to accept credit for the cardinal changes he made in the group.

His stance was telling. He refused to accept that he was instrumental in the transformation of the group guaranteeing its continued existence, its present reputation, success and growth. Talking about his achievements in transforming the ‘Tatas from a patriarchal concern to an institutional enterprise’ for which he said he had ‘spent a lot of time and energy’, he was unequivocal in maintaining that ‘it would … be a mark of [his] failure’ ‘if it were perceived that Ratan Tata epitomises the group’s success’. He said that he accorded importance to the teams that companies are and not ‘individuals’ and said: ‘If history remembers me at all, I hope it will be for this transformation’ and not for the remarkable changes that he wrought in Tata companies.

Ratan the Prankster

No one would expect the reclusive, reticent, media-shy Ratan to be a prankster. But he is one, and incorrigible at that.

His age never restrained the child in him. He would play pranks on his colleagues with great delight. During long board meetings, when he discovered that some of the ‘old guard’ would clandestinely relax by kicking off their shoes, he would kick their shoes as far away as he possibly could. He would then wait for the meeting to end, to watch the directors desperately moving their feet in all directions to locate their shoes. When